

****Quick Bridge:**** If you applied for an internal leadership role and lost to an outside hire, the interview is not where you lost it. Leaders usually know who they want before the posting goes up, based on relationships built long before any role opened. This post explains the dynamic most internal candidates do not see, and what it looks like to become a known quantity across your organization before you ever need to.

You Applied for the Internal Role. Here's Why You Didn't Get It.

Someone I mentor came to me last year wanting to know what went wrong in their interview. They had applied for an internal leadership role. They had the technical background. They knew the company inside out.

On paper, they were the right person.

They did not get it. The person who did was an outside hire.

I told them: the interview was not where you lost it. You lost it before the role was ever posted.

They looked at me like I had said something unfair. It is not unfair. It is just how this works, and nobody explains it until after the fact.

The Interview Never Stopped

Growing up, I was told something I have repeated to other people for my entire career. "Do not do a bad job because you never know when your next boss is watching."

Simple. Almost obvious. And completely true in ways I did not understand at the time.

Every year I speak to college students about career development. The interview started the first day of freshman year. Not after you have the diploma. Not when you apply for that internship.

Someone you know is going to have influence over your next role. How you showed up in every conversation, every interaction, before anyone was watching. That is what they remember.

In business, it works exactly the same way. When a leadership role opens internally, most of the time the leaders already know who they want before the posting goes live.

Is that fair? No. Is it reality? Yes.

[object Object]

The people who get tapped are the ones who have been showing up intentionally, not the ones who started positioning when they saw the job post.

The Internal Candidate Trap

Here is where most people get it wrong.

They apply for an internal role and assume that "internal candidate" means "known quantity." You work there. You understand the culture. You have company history that an outside hire would take a year to build.

That should count for something.

It does. And it only counts inside your own team.

I cannot tell you the number of people I have mentored who wanted to transfer into a management role in another department and had never spoken to anyone who worked in that area. Had never tried to understand what that team actually does. Had never built a relationship with that team's leader or any of its members. And then could not understand why they did not get the role.

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The hiring leader does not know how they think under pressure. Does not know how they handle ambiguity or communicate across teams. They know this person by reputation, and that reputation exists in exactly one corner of the organization.

An external hire is a known risk. The gap is visible on paper and you can plan for it. An internal candidate nobody knows is a hidden risk. Given a choice between the two, most leaders will go with the person they already trust.

Being internal does not make you a known quantity. Building relationships across the organization makes you a known quantity.

What Showing Up Actually Looks Like

This is not about attending more networking events or updating your LinkedIn profile. That is not the kind of advice that changes anything.

My own career did not move forward because I was good at my job. It moved when I got curious about how other teams worked and what mattered to them. I started looking for the problems nobody owned.

I followed my own interest in how things connected across the org. Eventually my company built a leadership role around the skill set I had developed.

I did not chase that role. I showed up in the right way long enough that the role found me.

****Build relationships before you need them.**** Not as a tactic. As a habit.

The people who will have influence over your next role are already in your organization. Most of them are not in your department.

I started by getting curious about adjacent teams. Not asking for anything. Just trying to understand what they worked on.

Ask someone you rarely work with to walk you through what their team is focused on this quarter. Do not pitch yourself. Just listen and ask follow-up questions. Show up for their work the way you would want them to show up for yours.

Do the work that crosses boundaries. Every organization has important problems that sit between teams. The ones nobody owns because they do not fit cleanly on any one team's roadmap. The leaders who get known step into those gaps before anyone asks them to.

Show up as a leader in the moments that do not seem to matter. How you handle a disagreement between two teams. How you treat people who have nothing to offer you right now. These are the moments that build the reputation that travels.

Your manager sees your work every day. The people who will have input on your next role see these moments.

The interview is always happening. That is not pressure. It is just context.

This Week

Identify one team or function you would want to work near eventually. Find one person on that team and ask to understand what they work on. Not to get anything from it. Just to learn.

That single conversation will not get you the next role. But the habit of doing it regularly, long before you need anything, is exactly how you become a known quantity somewhere new.

- Related reading:
- [Professional Relationships Drive Career Growth](<https://medium.com/@stafford.jesse>)

- [Your Peers Control Your Success. Here's How to Build Those Relationships.](<https://medium.com/@stafford.jesse>)

When you have watched someone get tapped for an internal role, what made them the obvious choice before the posting even went up?

You're great at the work. Let's make you impossible to ignore.

If you are looking for help building visibility and influence across your organization, consider reaching out.
jessestaffordcoaching.com

****Tags:**** Leadership, Management, Engineering Management, Career Advice, Professional Development

****Feature image prompt:**** Professional photo-realistic illustration of a person in conversation with colleagues in a modern open office, brand blue (#100299) accent tones, warm natural lighting, clean minimal style, career visibility and leadership theme, no text overlays